

**Colonized in Conservation: Human-Nonhuman Subjugation and the Ethics of Endangered
Species Care**

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Introduction of Themes

There is a restrictive, colonial grasp that renders too many of Earth's organisms colonized both in their lives and in their deaths. Often exhibiting a loss of physical freedom, personal autonomy, and general contentment, many threatened and endangered wildlife living in sanctuaries across the world exemplify this colonized existence. From the potent legal structures that set the parameters for conservation to the individual interactions between endangered orangutans and their human caretakers at the Batu and Lundu Wildlife Centers in Sarawak, Malaysia, Anthropologist Juno Salazar Parreñas explores both the macro and the micro ways in which colonialism and capitalism dictate conservation in her multispecies ethnography, *Decolonizing Extinction*. Parreñas ultimately conducts her research through the inquiry of what it means to be colonized in life and in death, and while orangutans are the primary nonhuman species in her exploration, the following analysis applies Parreñas' findings to the general discussion of wildlife conservation as a whole.

In answering the question of what it means to be colonized in life and in death, Parreñas introduces the underlying theme that both humans and wildlife are, to the same extent, animals. This truth suggests not only that our self-established superiority to wildlife is misguided, but also that human populations and orangutan populations alike can be — and often are — equivalently colonized in life and in death. It is only through sharing the orangutan's plight in this way, Parreñas contends, that one can truly understand the full extent of the orangutan's colonized condition. Scholarship often attempts to do so through scientific discovery and report, but without a shared subjugation to the strangling effects of colonialism and capitalism, it is impossible to gain a truly authentic understanding

of orangutan life and extinction. This concept of human-nonhuman shared experience is the backbone of Parreñas' multispecies ethnography, and to understand this phenomenon, it is important to investigate its specific manifestations which Parreñas so thoroughly records in her book. In the following section, I will describe a few of her salient findings as well as apply my own background in endangered wildlife conservation to offer some support for as well as criticisms of the conclusions that Parreñas draws.

Thematic Exploration 1: Human-Nonhuman Semi-Autonomy

The first of Parreñas' ideas I wish not to approach from an argumentative place of refutation or support but an analytical one of observation and understanding, and that is her idea that colonialism and capitalism determine how humans and orangutans alike can physically move in the world. Parreñas writes, "...thwarted freedom is a condition shared between almost everybody and every body in Batu. Batu's people and animals survive in an extractive economy with unequal exchange, in which a few people have the freedom to move both themselves and the world around them as they please" (2018, 133). It is no secret that the orangutans at Batu Wildlife Center are unable to venture permanently into their natural spaces, as resource and habitat destruction at the avaricious hands of capitalism has rendered the forests of Sarawak inadequate in their provision of food and sustenance for many of their native inhabitants; no matter how deeply these orangutans wish to flee to their ancestral, jungle-clad homes, they will eventually be compelled to return for food to Batu's man-made courtyard. Nadim, a Batu wildlife ranger, informs Parreñas that "'Wani [(an orangutan at the sanctuary)] was gone for 2 weeks and now she's back. I think she tried, but not enough food and nowhere to go. She

knows food is here” (as cited in Parreñas, 2018, 141). With the simultaneous and contradictory experiences of free movement and caretaker reliance, Batu’s and Lundu’s orangutans are, as understood in Malay, “*bebas, tapi takut*” — “free, but fearful.” Free, if they so choose, to live as the wild creatures that they were meant to be, but fearful of the harrowing death by starvation that will surely follow if they do.

Parreñas also describes the arrested autonomy of Batu’s laborers themselves which eerily parallels that of its orangutans. She writes, “...they all came [(to Lundu Wildlife Center)] for the same reason: they could no longer *cari makan* or find food in the forests of their ancestral homelands” (*Cari maken* in Malay literally means “to find food,” but the phrase is often used idiomatically in reference to earning a living) (2018, 112). The colonial system that continues to impose the domination of native lands and resources for capital gain (ultimately rendering Sarawak’s orangutans dependent on humans for basic subsistence) is the same one that drove Native Ibans in Borneo from their traditional livelihoods, cornering them into alternative and often exploitative means of *cari maken*, such as performing physically demanding manual labor at the Western-owned Batu and Lundu Wildlife Centers for wages below the national poverty line. “Lundu Wildlife Center,” Parreñas writes, “is both a site of refuge for animals that have lost their habitats and a workplace for Sarawakian Ibans who felt pushed to relocate from their ancestral homelands in the interior, who were unable to maintain a livelihood through subsistence farming, and who must earn the means to live in Sarawak’s cash economy” (2018, 105). Both Sarawakian orangutans and Sarawakian people exist under an illusory perception of freedom while ultimately being restricted to the grounds of Batu and Lundu, as these sanctuaries are often their only promise of being fed (in the case of the orangutan) and earning

the money so that they may be fed (in the case of the caretaker). It is the colonial displacement from their native lands and lifestyles that renders Sarawakian orangutans and humans alike physically shackled, and thus only semi-autonomous.

More than just physical movement, however, modern capitalism and its beneficiaries dictate figurative movement as well through the regulation of conservation policy. Amid the tension created by a revenue-oriented development plan whereby orangutan corridor space would be converted into a restroom area for tourists, Parreñas observes that “Nadim recognizes the coercion inherent in the caring act of offering food support to free-ranging orangutans that have ‘nowhere to go.’ He himself is stuck, unable to criticize the development around him and unable to provide anything more than food” (2018, 142). Due to Nadim’s and the orangutans’ shared colonization, Nadim truly understands what needs to be done in order to protect what is left of the orangutans’ restricted *bebas*, or freedom. He wants nothing more than to carry out what is necessary, but he cannot; his position beneath Batu’s leaders and the corporations with which they collaborate renders Nadim powerless in halting the impending damage to the homes of those he considers equals. Evidenced by this incident and echoed throughout Parreñas’ exploration, it is oftentimes not the heart of the conservationist but the avarice of the corporate world behind decisions related to wildlife. Layang, a caretaker at Lundu Wildlife Center, summarizes this phenomenon well in his succinct observation that “[i]t’s just all about money. That’s how you do conservation” (as cited in Parreñas, 2018, 145). Even though individuals like Nadim and Layang possess a deeply personal understanding of the orangutan’s plight and are thus perhaps the most qualified individuals to be consulted about related matters, their input is often valued the least. Parreñas highlights this restriction of thought when she inquires rhetorically, “How

can one move through the site, literally when trees acting as corridors are removed to build toilets, and figuratively when one's opinion is never solicited, when what should be done is impossible to do?" (2018, 156). These individuals are colonized both in movement and in thought, unable to physically *cari maken* outside of Sarawak's cash economy nor implement their critically valuable ideas through intellectual collaboration with those of higher economic and political influence.

Thematic Exploration 2: The Questionable Nature of Species Repopulation

Parreñas claims that to deem species repopulation the most crucial conservation effort is to blame the population decline on the species' own failure to reproduce rather than on the corporations that ravage the species' habitats, resources, and breeding grounds in the first place. What Parreñas fails to acknowledge in this assertion is that conservationists working to repopulate species often *do* understand the man-made nature of most population declines. I know this because I am one of those conservationists. From 2022-2023, I was a crane caretaker and assistant in repopulation at the International Crane Foundation (ICF), a conservation facility based in Wisconsin that has almost single-handedly raised the global population of whooping cranes from less than 50 individuals when it was founded in 1973 to now over 830 individuals in 2024. It was evidently quite jarring to me when, in the same breath as her mention of the unjust and detrimental nature of forced impregnation, Parreñas referenced "...[the] caretakers of whooping cranes in the United States who withdraw sperm from male cranes and artificially inseminate female cranes for the sake of future generations" (2018, 99). I wholeheartedly understand the reason for Parreñas' disapproval; she notes that because reproduction is the sole measurement of success at Batu Wildlife Center, the female orangutan's

discomfort and fear are merely collateral. Batu's priorities are undoubtedly controversial and Parreñas is right to offer her criticism of its management, but to assume that this is the case for all conservation facilities is to simplify the context at hand; the primary measure of success at ICF, along with its repopulation effort, is the welfare of the captive flock — both the physical welfare and the emotional. If a crane displays any signs of anxiety prior to artificial insemination procedures, ICF keepers will absolutely not go forth in the semen collection or the insemination process (respective to the sex of the anxious bird). I do acknowledge alongside Parreñas, however, that artificially inseminating a female crane (or in the case of orangutans, locking a male and female in a small space together so that the male can forcibly — and often violently — impregnate the female), does promote a gross lack of female choice. After all, while keepers at ICF would never go through with inseminating a visibly anxious bird, how are they to know that a female crane's tranquility necessarily denotes her consent? This is one of the many issues at the center of operating within a colonized system that renders wildlife voiceless, and humans their unsolicited mouthpiece.

Parreñas' final grievance about the effort of repopulation is that it ultimately fails to address the root of population decline (habitat destruction, poaching, etc.). This is a valid concern; merely working to repopulate a species, no matter how drastic the subsequent population increase, is never going to eliminate the corporate threat of habitat loss in the first place. It is true that repopulation is just a temporary treatment for a symptom rather than a cure for the illness itself, but I contend that it is perhaps the most significant and mandatory thing that we can do as conservationists. After all, Parreñas herself highlights the extreme limitations that individual caretakers often face in their conservation efforts (see the description of restricted figurative movement in Thematic Exploration 1).

We can either attempt the most dramatically effective thing in our power (repopulation), or let the endangered species in question very rapidly die out.

It is indisputable that in the process of artificial insemination, many female whooping cranes are subjected to uncomfortable and invasive procedures, but so, too, are many conservationists subjected to the constrained reality that renders us yearning for the end of habitat destruction but often completely powerless against the unyielding legal entities that enable it. When we do not possess the immediate political influence necessary to address the root of the problem — to halt the corporate practices that ravage native habitats and breedings grounds and subsequently expedite population decline — then we have to turn to the next best thing in our power. I agree with Parreñas that to prioritize forced impregnation is to play along with capitalism's strangling hold on conservation, but I also believe that if operating under this strangling hold is the best that we can do with the resources we have, then we must continue to do so; we are sparing hundreds of species their unnatural and cruelly premature extinctions, and we cannot cease this intervention merely for the purpose of achieving a symbolic decolonization of death.

Rather than letting this colonized state of conservation call for the ceasing of our already limited efforts, I believe we should instead let it prompt our radical awareness and inquiry about the situation, something that Parreñas does beautifully when introducing her research. She questions, “What if we experienced this present era of extinction without violent domination and colonization over others, particularly nonhuman beings? ...Can we abandon an impression of safety that depends on cruelty? In other words, how might we decolonize extinction?” (2018, 3) In lieu of terminating our desperate repopulation efforts, let us conduct these efforts in the interim as we use our awareness of

colonized extinction to pose questions, to revise our own thinking, and to ultimately seek solutions that we may one day be able to implement in the name of decolonizing extinction.

Thematic Exploration 3: The Necessity to Listen to the Animal

When considering the underlying theme of anthropocentrism in Parreñas' ethnographic work, I cannot help but ask the following questions: What constitutes the "self?" Why is the "self" almost exclusively a human concept and not something that also pertains to nonhuman beings? I recall my time at ICF when I was caring for a flock of nearly 100 cranes, all fifteen of the world's species represented among them. I would always instinctively think of and verbally refer to the cranes as people: *"This morning I heard so many people unison calling in response to the migratory geese overhead!"* Whenever I drew this subconscious parallel between birds and humans, without failure my coworkers would correct me: *"Birds,"* they would say. *"You mean there were so many birds unison calling."* I always wondered why they felt it was necessary to correct my equating of cranes and humans, and in traversing Parreñas' research, I have found the answer: To my coworkers, the cranes were certainly not on the same level as human beings. To them, there was some inherent, categorical ranking that put us humans not in the category of "animal," but in a completely separate ranking of importance. Parreñas evidently highlights this biased separation between human beings and nonhuman beings in her observation that "...[d]ecolonization demands a serious challenge to the so-called great divides between human and animal..." (2018, 7). Parreñas implies here that our colonized system is one in which humans are not actually animals; that in order for these colonial legacies to thrive as they are, the lie of anthropocentrism must be enforced (it is also worth noting here that

anthropocentrism and its devaluing of nonhumans is what has historically and presently still enabled the colonial conquering and exploitation of Native populations globally; in viewing tribal peoples as animals and thus *sub*human, colonial entities are able to treat them as such). Anthropocentrism is an intentional and calculated structure. I believe that without it, colonialism would have no footing and our world today would abundantly reflect the interspecies *bebas* that is now critically endangered under our colonial and capitalistic systems.

Perhaps the most salient concept to extract from Parreñas' research is the imperative for humans to listen not to our own cultivated beliefs, but to the animal itself. Why do we think that we know more about orangutans than orangutans know about themselves? Just as a woman is infinitely more qualified than a male politician to decide what is best for her own body, an orangutan, a whooping crane — any animal alive for that matter — is infinitely more qualified than a human scientist to decide what is best for its environment and for its care. Parreñas reveals that while the caretakers at Batu Wildlife Center are instructed to intervene in any fight that occurs between the orangutans and in any scenario that might put an infant orangutan at risk, they are instructed *not* to intervene in acts of sexual violence. As Batu supervisors reason, acts of sexual violence between the orangutans are natural and should run their course. Why then, are caretakers to break up the other natural forms of natural violence in which the orangutans engage? What gives us the authority to selectively permit certain natural behaviors of a species outside of our own? It is imperative that we adjust how we conserve and protect wildlife according to what their lived experience tells us *must* happen, rather than what our lived experience tells us *should* happen. As echoed beautifully by

Parreñas, “To decolonize extinction is to resist definitively saying what should be or ought to be” (2018, 7).

Conclusion

The previous thematic explorations point to the linchpin of Parreñas’ work, and that is the question of who gets to determine how species live and die. Through the course of her ethnography, Parreñas urges us to consider the following: that we as human beings do not possess an omniscient understanding of nonhuman beings and are thus in no place to govern their lives and extinctions as though we did; that while human beings might subconsciously discriminate based on species, the forces of colonialism and capitalism certainly do not, and that consequently, there is a colonized lived experience shared equivalently between captive wildlife and certain human populations (namely, Native Ibans living in Sarawak and other groups of Indigenous Peoples around the world); that intrinsically, it is orangutans that know orangutans best, and that only through experiencing the aforementioned parallelism firsthand can one be deeply, personally acquainted with the colonized plight of endangered wildlife and thus truly qualified to inform related matters.

Ultimately, it is impossible to begin decolonizing both our understanding of wildlife extinction as well as our attendant conservation practices without turning to the Native communities that are sorely familiar with the plight of the endangered, uniquely rich with a wealth of inimitable insight on that account, and all-too-constantly dismissed by those in power who often set the parameters for conservation policy. In the important quest to decolonize extinction, we must abandon our groundless anthropocentrism, we must seek the counsel of those living parallel to endangered

wildlife, and we must cultivate the ability to imagine new ways of living and dying. We must, in the words of Batu wildlife ranger Nadim, “[t]hink what the orangutan are thinking” (as cited in Parreñas, 2018, 14).

References

Parreñas, Juno Salazar. 2018. *Decolonizing Extinction: The Work of Care in Orangutan Rehabilitation*. Durham and London: Duke University Press.